

Other virtualization software

Although VirtualBox and VMware workstation rule the show, there are a few others which are not so famous. The list would include:

- ▶ **Microsoft Virtual PC:** This software is an offering from the behemoth itself. However, there are limitations with it. First, it was never said to give good performance; nor was it ever high on the features list. In addition, it can only work on Windows which means that it's completely useless for a Linux or Mac user. All in all, this makes it a not-so-good virtualization software package.
- ▶ **Hyper-V:** You can call it the KVM for Windows. Hyper-V is the virtualization feature built into Windows Server 2008. It allows you to make use of the virtualization assistive technologies (Intel VT-x and AMD-V) on the Windows Server machine. It can be used for creating cloud computing infrastructure or for providing virtual machines as a service over the network. Since the Windows "Server" series of operating systems are not for normal users, this one isn't one of those you might want to use.
- ▶ **Parallels:** We mentioned Parallels when talking about the various hard disk formats supported by VirtualBox. Parallels, like VMware, is a company with a complete range of products. The Parallels Workstation is its desktop virtualization product. Although a lot cheaper than VMware Workstation, it offers some good features. The features however are close to those of VirtualBox rather than VMware Workstation. Download the trial and see for yourself. One unique feature of Parallels Workstation is its ability to package your running machine into a virtual hard disk which could be booted on Parallels Workstation; but that's not so smooth in any way. The biggest trouble you'd run into – it simply tries to bunch everything together! So you don't have the option of selecting the folders you don't want in the target virtual hard disk. Your tens of GBs of multimedia collection is what would make the overall size of the target quite huge. If you have 320GB hard disk space in total, chances are you have at least half of it filled up. Now imagine transferring 160+ GB of data over ethernet wire! If you don't have a network, get yourself an external disk of that size to get that done. The second problem with this feature is that it has a strict set of OS support. For example, it supports Ubuntu 11.04 but when we tried to pack the system running Ubuntu 11.10, it complained with a message indicating its impotency to convert the running OS into a bootable virtual hard disk. Still, if you're interested in this feature, Parallels might just be for you.